

Aetiology & Pathogenesis

Causes of Disease in East Asian Medicine — the Six Exogenous Factors, Seven Emotions, Improper Diet, Overstrain, Phlegm & Blood Stasis

風	寒	暑	濕	燥	火
Fēng · Wind	Hán · Cold	Shǔ · Summer Heat	Shī · Dampness	Zào · Dryness	Huǒ · Fire
Spring	Winter	Summer only	Late Summer	Autumn	All seasons

Core Principle: Zhèng Qì vs Xié Qì

Disease occurs when the equilibrium between the human body and its environment breaks down. **Xié Qì** 邪氣 (pathogenic Qì) cannot invade a body where **Zhèng Qì** 正氣 (anti-pathogenic Qì) is strong. The internal factor — body resistance — is primary. "Pathogenic qì cannot invade the body if the anti-pathogenic qì remains strong." (Plain Questions Ch. 72)

The Six Exogenous Pathogenic Factors — Liù Yīn 六淫

六淫

What Are They?

Wind, Cold, Summer Heat, Dampness, Dryness, and Fire are the six climatic changes. They cause disease when: (1) climatic changes are extreme or sudden, or (2) the body's resistance is low. They invade from the exterior via skin, mouth, or nose. They may combine and transform into each other.

① Wind 風 (Fēng) · Spring · Primary Yáng Pathogen · "Leader of all pathogens"

Nature

Spring · all seasons

- Primary pathogen — others (Cold, Damp, etc.) depend on Wind to invade
- Yáng — upward & outward dispersion; easily invades head, face, exterior
- Rapid changes; migratory symptoms; constant movement

Clinical Signs

- Headache; nasal obstruction; aversion to wind; sweating
- Migratory joint pain (Wind Bi); urticaria (wheals appear/disappear)
- Dizziness; tremors; convulsions; deviation of mouth/eyes

Key Combinations

- Wind-Cold: aversion to cold, no sweating, tight pulse
- Wind-Heat: fever, sore throat, slight sweating, rapid pulse
- Wind-Phlegm: facial paralysis, stroke-like

Pulse: Floating · **Tongue:** thin white

② Cold 寒 (Hán) · Winter · Primary Yīn Pathogen · Contracting

Nature

Winter

- Yīn pathogen — consumes Yáng Qì → impairs warming function
- Contracts & stagnates — closes pores; spasm of tendons; impairs Qì & Blood circulation → **pain**

Clinical Signs

- Pronounced aversion to cold; preference for warmth
- No sweating; no thirst; loose stools; clear profuse urine
- Pain worse with cold, better with warmth
- Pale face; cold limbs; restricted movement

Key Distinctions

- Exterior Cold: sudden, floating-tight pulse
- Interior Full Cold: pain worse with pressure, pale tongue, thick white coat
- Interior Empty Cold: chronic, dull ache better with pressure, weak pulse
- Cold can transform into Interior Heat

Pulse: Tight/Slow · **Tongue:** pale white moist

③ Summer Heat 暑 (Shǔ) · Summer ONLY · Pure Yáng · No Endogenous Form

Nature

Summer ONLY

- Unique — only occurs in summer; no endogenous form
- Extreme heat; upward direction; disperses & consumes fluids & Qì
- Affects head & eyes; opens pores → profuse sweating

Clinical Signs

- High fever; restlessness; strong thirst; profuse sweating; surging pulse
- Dizziness; blurred vision; dry mouth; scanty dark urine
- Lassitude; reluctance to speak (concurrent Qì deficiency)
- Sunstroke: sudden collapse, loss of consciousness

Key Combination

- **Summer Heat + Dampness** (most common in clinical practice — humid summers): dizziness, heaviness, nausea, chest suffocation, poor appetite, lassitude + fever, restlessness, thirst

Pulse: Surging-Rapid · **Tongue:** red, dry coat

④ Dampness 濕 (Shī) · Late Summer · Yīn · Sticky, Stagnant, Intractable

Nature

Late Summer · damp environments

- Yīn pathogen — impairs Yáng; obstructs Qì circulation
- Heavy & turbid — heaviness of body; head like wrapped in cloth; soreness & pain in joints
- Viscous & stagnant — prolonged, intractable diseases (eczema, intestinal typhoid)
- Impairs Spleen Yáng (Spleen likes dryness)

Clinical Signs

- Heaviness of body and limbs; head wrapped in cloth sensation
- Full sensation in chest; epigastric distention
- Obstructed urination; viscous stools with mucus
- Turbid discharges (suppurating sores, weeping eczema, leucorrhoea)
- Poor appetite; loose stools; oedema

Key Points

- Causes: damp environments, damp clothes, frequent water exposure, Late Summer season
- Damp-Heat: jaundice, turbid urine, yellow greasy coat
- Damp-Cold: fixed Bì syndrome; abdominal pain worse with cold
- Endogenous Dampness: Spleen def failing to transform fluids

Pulse: Slippery/Soggy · **Tongue:** thick sticky coat

⑤ Dryness 燥 (Zào) · Autumn · Consumes Fluids · "Delicate Lung"

Nature

Autumn · dry climates

- Consumes body fluids → universal sign: dryness everywhere
- Often impairs the Lung (the "delicate" Zang) through nose or mouth

Clinical Signs

- Dry nose/throat; dry mouth with thirst; chapped lips; wrinkled skin; constipation; reduced urination
- Dry cough with scanty, sticky or bloody sputum (Lung impaired)
- Dark yellow scanty urine (with heat component)

Key Distinctions

- Cool Dryness: like Exterior Cold + dryness; aversion to cold, no sweating
- Warm Dryness: like Exterior Heat + dryness; fever, headache
- Endogenous Dryness: from Yin def, Blood def, sweating/bleeding/fluid loss

Pulse: Fine · **Tongue:** dry, little coat

⑥ Fire 火 (Huǒ) · All Seasons · Extreme Yáng · Three Internal Sources

Nature

All seasons — most severe

- Extreme Yáng — burning & upward direction
- Consumes Yin fluids; stirs up Wind; disturbs Blood; generates abscesses
- 3 Internal Sources: external Yáng pathogen; internally generated (emotional/diet); transformation of other pathogens (even Cold → Heat)

Clinical Signs

- High fever; restlessness; thirst; sweating; dark urine; constipation
- Mouth/tongue ulcers; swollen gums; red eyes; headache
- Mania, emotional excitement, coma/delirium (disturbs Shen)
- Bleeding: epistaxis, haemoptysis, bloody stool/urine
- Abscesses, carbuncles, boils (degenerates flesh)

Two Key Effects

- **Stirs up Wind** — extreme heat → Liver Wind → high fever + convulsions, neck rigidity, opisthotonos, upward staring eyes ("extreme heat generates Wind")
- **Disturbs Blood** — speeds circulation → rapid pulse; forces blood out of vessels → bleeding; chronic → abscesses

Pulse: Rapid · **Tongue:** red, yellow/dry coat

Memory: Wind=Spring · Cold=Winter · Summer Heat=Summer ONLY (no endogenous form) · Dampness=Late Summer · Dryness=Autumn · Fire=All seasons. **Yin pathogens:** Cold, Dampness. **Yang pathogens:** Wind, Summer Heat, Dryness, Fire.

Six Exogenous Factors — Master Reference Table

Factor	Season	Yin/Yang	Key Nature	Primary Signs	Target Organ	Pulse · Tongue
Wind 風	Spring (any)	Yáng	Primary pathogen; upward & outward; rapid/migratory	Headache, aversion to wind, migratory pain, sweating, dizziness, tremors	Lung (skin), Liver	Floating · thin white
Cold 寒	Winter	Yīn	Consumes Yáng; contracts; stagnates; causes pain	Aversion to cold, no sweating, no thirst, pain worse with cold	Kidney, Spleen, Stomach	Tight/Slow · pale white
Summer Heat 暑	Summer ONLY	Yáng (extreme)	Extreme; upward; disperses & consumes fluids; NO endogenous form	High fever, profuse sweating, thirst, surging pulse, collapse, concurrent Qì def	Heart, Lung	Surging-Rapid · red dry
Dampness 濕	Late Summer	Yīn (heavy)	Viscous & stagnant; heavy & turbid; impairs Yáng; Spleen hates Damp	Heaviness, head wrapped in cloth, turbid discharges, prolonged disease	Spleen (primary)	Slippery/Soggy · thick sticky
Dryness 燥	Autumn	Middle	Consumes fluids; impairs Lung; dries everything	Dry nose/throat/mouth/cough/lips/skin, constipation, reduced urination	Lung (primary)	Fine · dry, little coat
Fire 火	All seasons	Yáng (extreme)	Burning & upward; consumes Yin; stirs Wind; disturbs Blood; 3 sources	High fever, red face, thirst, bleeding, ulcers, mania, constipation	Heart (Shen), Liver, all	Rapid · red, yellow/dry

The Seven Emotions — Qī Qíng 七情

七情

Key Principle

Primary internal causative factor. Directly affect Zang-Fu organs, Qì, and Blood. Normal emotions do not cause disease — only when severe, continuous, or abrupt. Heart, Liver, and Spleen most involved. "Anger injures the Liver, joy injures the Heart, grief & melancholy injure the Lung, worry injures the Spleen, and fear & fright injure the Kidney."

① Anger 怒 (Nù)

→ Liver · Qi rises ↑

Impairs Liver free flow of Qi. Distension & pain in hypochondrium, irascibility, belching, sighing, foreign body in throat, irregular menstruation. Severe: bleeding.

② Joy 喜 (Xǐ)

→ Heart · Qi slows

Excessive joy disturbs Heart's dominance of mental activities. Palpitations, insomnia, dream-disturbed sleep, mental confusion, mania, abnormal laughing/crying.

③ Melancholy 憂 (Yōu)

→ Lung · Spleen · Qi disperses

Consumes Qi; impairs Lung & Spleen. Epigastric distention, anorexia, SOB, fatigue, melancholy.

④ Worry 思 (Sī)

→ Spleen · Heart · Qi stagnates

Impairs Spleen transportation & transformation. Overthinking, poor concentration, poor appetite, loose stools, fatigue, palpitations.

⑤ Grief 悲 (Bēi)

→ Lung · Qi disperses & weakens

Impairs Lung dispersing & descending. SOB, spontaneous sweating, fatigue, susceptibility to illness, sadness, inability to let go.

⑥ Fear 恐 (Kǒng)

→ Kidney · Qi descends ↓

Injures Kidney Qi → Qi descends → loss of bladder/bowel control. Dizziness, tinnitus, back weakness, frequent urination, incontinence, seminal emission.

⑦ Fright 驚 (Jīng)

→ Heart · Kidney · Qi deranged

Sudden/acute (vs chronic Fear). Disturbs Heart → palpitations, racing heart, insomnia, anxiety, restlessness.

Qi Movements

Anger → Qi rises ↑

Joy → Qi slows

Grief/Melancholy → Qi disperses

Fear → Qi descends ↓

Fright → Qi deranged (scattered)

Worry → Qi stagnates

Other Causes & Secondary Pathogens

Improper Diet, Overstrain & Lifestyle

Cause	Pathology & Clinical Signs
Overeating	Impairs SP & ST → foul belching, sour regurgitation, distention, pain, nausea, vomiting, diarrhea
Malnutrition	Fails to provide basis for Qi & Blood → weight loss, weakness, poor immunity
Excess cold/raw food	Injures Spleen Yang → interior Cold & Damp → abdominal pain, diarrhea
Excess alcohol/greasy/spicy	Produces Damp-Heat, Phlegm, Qi & Blood stagnation → chest fullness, sputum, haemorrhoids, carbuncles
Overstrain & stress	Consumes Qi & Blood → weight loss, lassitude, palpitations, dizziness, disturbed sleep, SOB
Excessive sexual activity	Injures Kidney Qi → lower back/knee weakness, dizziness, tinnitus, impotence, irregular menstruation
Lack of exercise	Impairs Qi & Blood circulation; weakens SP & ST → soft bones/tendons, poor energy, poor appetite, obesity

Secondary Pathogens — Phlegm Fluid 痰飲 & Stagnant Blood 瘀血

Critical Concept: Secondary Pathogens Are Both Product AND Cause

Phlegm and Stagnant Blood are **pathological products** of organ dysfunction. Once produced, they further affect organs and cause disease — making them also **causative factors** themselves.

Secondary Pathogen	Formation	Clinical Manifestations
Phlegm Fluid 痰飲	Accumulation of body fluid from dysfunction of LU, SP, KD & impaired water metabolism. Phlegm = turbid/thick; Retained Fluid = clear/dilute	Lung → cough, asthma; Heart → palpitations, coma, mania; Meridians → numbness, hemiplegia; Head/eyes → dizziness; Throat → "foreign body" sensation (梅核氣); Skin → oedema; Chest → distention & cough; ST/Intestines → nausea, borborygmus
Stagnant Blood 瘀血	Impaired blood circulation from Cold, Qi def, Qi stagnation; or traumatic injuries causing internal blood accumulation	Heart → chest pain, purple lips; Lung → haemoptysis; GI → bloody stools; Liver → hypochondriac pain, abdominal masses; Uterus → dysmenorrhoea, dark clots; Body surface → purplish skin. Common: fixed stabbing pain, purple tongue, Choppy/Wiry/Firm pulse

Exam Memory — Three Categories of Causes: **External** = Six Exogenous Factors (enter from outside via skin/nose/mouth). **Internal** = Seven Emotions (directly affect Zang-Fu). **Neither Internal nor External** = diet, overwork, sexual excess, trauma. Phlegm & Blood Stasis are **secondary** — pathological products that become pathogens.